President was scheduled to meet the Soviet Foreign Minister, Andrei Gromyko, in two days' time, there was an available opportunity for a private *démarche*. On 16 October 1962 President Kennedy was clear about which option he preferred. At the end of the first meeting with his advisers, he stated:

> We can't wait two weeks while we're getting ready to roll. Maybe we just have to just take them out, and continue our other preparations if we decide to do that. That may be where we end up. I think we ought, to beginning right now, preparing to present what we're going to do *anyway.*We're certainly going to do number one. We're going to take out these missiles. The questions will be whether, what I would describe as number two, which would be a general air strike. That we're not ready to say, but we should be in preparation for it. The third is the general invasion. At least we're going to do number one. So it seems to me that we don't have to wait very long. We ought to be making *those* preparations.[20]

For several days, JFK was wedded to an air strike, though unconvinced of the case for invasion. On 16 October McNamara told him that, 'If it were absolutely essential,' an attack on the missiles 'could be done almost literally within a matter of hours.'[21] This would attack those targets identified by the U-2 overflight of 14 October. Later that day, he explained that the Joint Chiefs needed twenty-four hours warning to hit the missiles, MiG aircraft, and nuclear storage sites. The earliest an attack could be mounted was Saturday, 20 October (if the order was given on Friday, 19 October).

This timetable is of interest. As noted earlier, Colonel Oleg Penkovsky spied for SIS and CIA from within Soviet military intelligence before his arrest by the KGB on 22 October. He provided the West with a treasure trove of secret intelligence, including material about operational features of the R-12. Richard Helms, then CIA Deputy Director of Plans, believed that Penkovsky's material on the MRBM enabled US decision-makers to know